

# Psalms 36

## *The Fountain of Life*

For with thee is the fountain of life  
KJV · Standalone study handout

### 1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *The transgression of the wicked saith within my heart, that there is no fear of God before his eyes.*
- 2 *For he flattereth himself in his own eyes, until his iniquity be found to be hateful.*
- 3 *The words of his mouth are iniquity and deceit: he hath left off to be wise, and to do good.*
- 4 *He deviseth mischief upon his bed; he setteth himself in a way that is not good; he abhorreth not evil.*
- 5 *Thy mercy, O LORD, is in the heavens; and thy faithfulness reacheth unto the clouds.*
- 6 *Thy righteousness is like the great mountains; thy judgments are a great deep: O LORD, thou preservest man and beast.*
- 7 *How excellent is thy lovingkindness, O God! therefore the children of men put their trust under the shadow of thy wings.*
- 8 *They shall be abundantly satisfied with the fatness of thy house; and thou shalt make them drink of the river of thy pleasures.*
- 9 *For with thee is the fountain of life: in thy light shall we see light.*
- 10 *O continue thy lovingkindness unto them that know thee; and thy righteousness to the upright in heart.*
- 11 *Let not the foot of pride come against me, and let not the hand of the wicked remove me.*
- 12 *There are the workers of iniquity fallen: they are cast down, and shall not be able to rise.*

### 2 · CONTEXT

Psalm 36 opens by describing the wicked's self-flattering, fearless transgression, planned even while lying in bed, then pivots dramatically at verse 5 to the vastness of God's mercy, faithfulness, righteousness, and judgments, described as reaching to the heavens and the great deep. Verse 9's "fountain of life" and light imagery undergird much later hymnody and echo forward into John's Gospel (John 1:4; 4:14). Henry reads the contrast as intentional: the wicked's darkness is small and self-contained, while God's goodness is immense and freely available.

### 3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

*The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.*

#### Verse 1-4

Transgression speaks within the wicked man's heart: no fear of God before his eyes, self-flattering deceit, a mind that has "left off to be wise," devising mischief even while lying on his bed.

#### Verse 5-6

By contrast, God's mercy reaches to the heavens, His faithfulness to the clouds, His righteousness stands like the great mountains, and His judgments are like a great deep—vast and unsearchable, yet He preserves both man and beast.

#### Verse 7-9

The excellency of God's lovingkindness draws the children of men to trust under the shadow of His wings; they are abundantly satisfied and drink from "the river of thy pleasures," for with Him is the fountain of life and in His light we see light.

#### Verse 10-12

A prayer that God's lovingkindness continue to the upright, that the foot of pride and the hand of the wicked not move him; the psalm ends noting the workers of iniquity have already fallen, cast down, unable to rise.

### 4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

#### Meaning.

The wicked's self-deception is a small, dark, private world compared to the sheer scale of God's mercy and faithfulness, which is public, cosmic, and freely available to all who trust Him. Life itself, and the light by which anything is truly seen, has its source in God alone.

#### Application for life today.

When you notice self-flattery creeping in—excusing sin because you have "left off to be wise"—let verses 5–9 recalibrate you toward God's immense goodness rather than your own small justifications. Practice naming God as the fountain you actually drink from this week, rather than seeking satisfaction from lesser sources. Pray verse 11 specifically over any pride or hostility you are currently facing.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. Where have you caught yourself flattering your own conscience the way verse 2 describes the wicked doing?

---

---

2. What would it mean practically to “drink of the river of thy pleasures” (v. 8) instead of a lesser source of satisfaction this week?

---

---

3. How does the picture of God’s mercy reaching “unto the heavens” change the way you view a current struggle with pride or opposition?

---

---

Name: \_\_\_\_\_ Date: \_\_\_\_\_ Group / Church: \_\_\_\_\_

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).